# Black

**Protection · depth · mystery**

Black can be an evening dress, ink, charcoal, the dark behind the window or a favourite T-shirt that has been through so many washes it is slowly applying to become grey. At times it is festive, at others sad. Sometimes it protects you from attention, at other times you walk into a room in it and nobody overlooks you. It depends on who wears it, where and with what feeling.

This page does not tell you what black means. **It shows it to you from several sides**. How it is mixed, how it is painted with, where its reputation comes from, how it is read in different cultures and **what it can awaken in us**.

## Contents

1. How to mix the colour and its shades 2

2. Rainbow – the chakra system 5

3. Free painting – intuition 8

4. Associations and stories 11

5. Emotions and feelings 13

6. Black in cultures and traditions 16

7. Colour frequency and phototherapy 25

8. Astrotype and colours 26

9. Colour for your website and business 45

10. Different colour combinations 49



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## How to mix the colour and its shades

**Black from a tube is not the only possible black.** Black pigments can be based, for example, on carbon or iron oxides. It can also be mixed from colours that mute each other. Each way turns out a little differently and each has its own undertone.

Not every pair of colours makes a truly deep black. Some mixtures end up brown or grey. **You will see the undertone only after lightening.** Take a little of the black mixture and add white. Suddenly a blue, brown or greenish tinge may show.

### What to prepare



**Ready-made black**
*For example carbon black or black iron oxide. Individual pigments differ.*



**Dark blue**
*For example ultramarine for a colour-mixed black.*



**Burnt umber**
*Dark brown to go with blue.*



**Dark green**
*For other deep mixtures.*



**Dark red**
*Together with green it makes a deep dark.*



**White**
*For lightening and recognising the undertone.*

### Colour-mixed black

You can get a dark mixture close to black by combining suitable pigments that mute each other. **One practical way is ultramarine blue with burnt umber.** A predominance of blue creates a cooler impression, a predominance of umber a warmer one.

This also explains the mystery of two black garments that suddenly "don't go together" in daylight. Black pretends to be simple. In fact it has family quarrels too.



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## What the additions do



### Blue

*Shifts toward a cold blue-black. Add by the tip.*





### Umber

*Shifts toward warm and softer. Too much umber makes it brown.*





### Green

*Shifts toward green-black, woodland and deep.*





### Violet

*Shifts toward violet-black, evening-like and mysterious.*





### White

*Lightens to anthracite and smoky. You will see the undertone.*





### Ochre

*Warms toward a warmer impression. Only the tip of the brush.*





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## Ten blacks to try

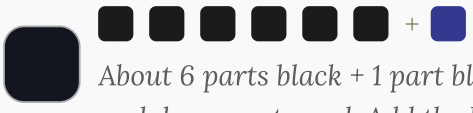
A part can be a drop, or an equally big heap of paint. The strength of pigments differs, so **take the ratios as a starting point for trying**.

### Neutral dark



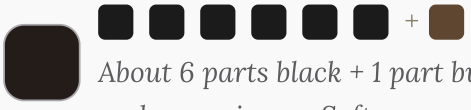
*Start with roughly equal parts of ultramarine and burnt umber, then adjust the ratio. Colour-mixed, livelier than black from a tube. More blue cools it, more umber warms it.*

### Blue-black



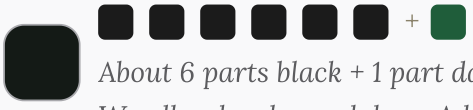
*About 6 parts black + 1 part blue. Cold and deep, nocturnal. Add the blue in small pinches.*

### Warm black



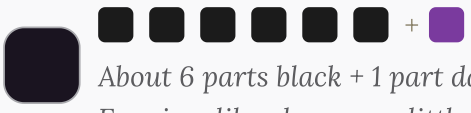
*About 6 parts black + 1 part burnt umber or sienna. Soft, warm, coffee-like. Suits shadows.*

### Green-black



*About 6 parts black + 1 part dark green. Woodland, calm and deep. Add the green carefully, it quickly takes the lead.*

### Violet-black



*About 6 parts black + 1 part dark violet. Evening-like, dreamy, a little mysterious.*

### Deep from colours



*Dark green and a suitable dark red, without black from a tube. Adjust the ratio according to the pigments, try in small parts. Deep and coloured, black only to the eye.*

### Anthracite



*Black and a small amount of white, possibly a drop of blue. Firm, cool and modern. Add the white gradually.*

### Smoky



*Black and more white, possibly a faint colour tinge. Soft and misty, on the edge of grey. Suits backgrounds and distance.*

### Soot



*Black, a tip of umber and a trace of white. Natural, matte, recalling soot. Holds together splendidly with clay and paper.*

### Ink



*More ultramarine and a little black. Deep as night with a hint of blue. Add the black in small portions so the blue does not vanish.*



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# Rainbow – the chakra system

Black has **no stripe of its own** in the rainbow. We usually perceive it on a surface when little visible light returns from it to the eyes relative to its surroundings. It is not one separate wavelength nor the "lowest spiritual frequency". In some contemporary approaches it accompanies the **root chakra** and the themes of protection, boundaries and grounding.

## The whole rainbow as a map of questions



**Red · root**

*Support, safety, presence. Ask yourself. What can I lean on?*



**Orange · sacral**

*Experiencing, pleasure, sensuality. Ask yourself. What does me good?*



**Yellow · solar plexus**

*Self-worth, will, decision-making. Ask yourself. What do I want to choose for myself?*



**Green · heart**

*Closeness, kindness, relationships. Ask yourself. Where can I be open and still stay with myself?*



**Blue · throat**

*Voice, expression, communication. Ask yourself. What do I need to say?*



**Indigo · third eye**

*Inner vision, intuition, discernment. Ask yourself. What is beginning to dawn on me?*



**Violet · crown**

*Transcendence, meaning, connection. Ask yourself. What gives me a wider sense of meaning?*



**Black · beside the root**

*Protection and boundaries. Ask yourself. Do I need to show something, or keep it to myself for now?*



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## The root chakra and boundaries

**Chakras come from the Indian yogic and tantric tradition.** The first chakra is called Muladhara, sits at the base of the spine and in classical texts red is linked with it. Black is added to it only in some contemporary spiritual approaches, as a symbol of protection, boundaries and grounding.

**That does not mean black is a colour of "bad energy"** or that liking black shows a closed chakra. Nor is the claim that black fabric automatically absorbs other people's negativity a proven physical effect. Absorbing light and a personal sense of protection are different things.

**When black does you good.** Firmness and a striking line feel pleasant. In it you feel well put together and private, and you can be seen in it, or on the contrary need not be at the centre of attention.

**When black does not do you good.** Everything blends together, it weighs on you or reminds you of a period you want to step away from. These are not proofs of the state of a chakra, they are situations in which you can get to know yourself.

## Protection that is not a wall

- **Put it beside**
  A black fabric next to a colour that attracts you. Perceive them for a while without looking for the right meaning.
- **Take it in your hand**
  A black scarf, a smooth stone or a piece of fabric as a personal symbol of privacy. Ask what you want to keep only to yourself today.
- **Put it on**
  Simple black clothes after a long period when you were constantly available. Less need to explain yourself.
- **Put it in a room**
  One black frame, shelf or lamp. A black frame does not behave like a black room.
- **Paint it**
  One decisive stroke on light paper. Notice your hand, the pressure and whether you want to continue.
- **Switch off for a while**
  Dimness can help create privacy and rest. Notice whether it feels pleasant.



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### When there is already too much black

Work with boundaries need not end in a firm "nobody in". Perhaps you do not need to share everything. But perhaps you are already hiding even what you would like to say. **You do not need more black.** You need to invite other colours.

- **With red**
  Do I feel support, or too much hardness?
- **With pink or green**
  Is there room for closeness?
- **With blue**
  Can I say something aloud?
- **With yellow or white**
  Do I see room for my own decision? Does a clear boundary suit me, or is the contrast too sharp?

This is inspiration from tradition, not treatment. It is not about measuring chakras. You notice how the relationship of colours affects you and what theme it reminds you of.

## Picture it with an example

Next to black other colours can stand out strongly. Yellow starts to feel sharper, pink bolder, green may recall leaves emerging from shadow. **These are possibilities for personal reading**, not effects prescribed by a colour combination.

## How to use this map

It is a way to sort out the themes you are living through. Do you add a colour because next to black you miss liveliness, or do you not need it because calm is enough? **You choose the meaning.** Both options can be fine.

Black has no place in the classical seven-colour map, not even an eighth.



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# Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, without a goal and without trying to make a pretty picture, we often reach for black when we want **a firm mark**, or when we need **silence and depth**. But we do not always know why. Sometimes we know exactly, sometimes not at all. Both are fine.

## What may hide behind a black stroke

The same black area on paper can mean **something completely different each time**, depending on what is going on in us. That is why it makes no sense to read a picture like a test with a single right answer.

**Strength.**

*Decisive strokes, a wide brush, charcoal. With one stroke you change something and it shows.*

**Silence.**

*A large dark area from which nothing is offered. A space in which one can rest.*

**Night.**

*Black with light points or a window. A darkness in which one can dream.*

**Boundary.**

*A line that separates and joins. A thin black line can say more than a coloured area.*

**Sadness.**

*A dense dark overlay, often over livelier places. Something that cannot be shown yet.*

**Joy in contrast.**

*Black on a light ground. The pleasure of there being something to see.*

## Black in a picture. Can it express what is happening inside?

Yes, it **can**, but it **does not have to**. A black picture is not automatically a message of misfortune. With black you can paint strength, calm, anger, silence, night and also joy in a striking mark. Sometimes you are attracted precisely by the fact that it does not dissolve into inconspicuousness. The amount of black alone does not determine your mental state. That holds even when black is used by a child.

While working you do not have to decide what exactly it means. Notice the hand, the pressure and whether you want to go on. Meaning comes only in connection with **your experience**.



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## I want it on the canvas, but I don't dare put it on myself

A picture and a dress ask two completely different things of you. Black in a picture can be quiet and beautiful, and yet you do not feel like going about in all-black clothes. Or the other way round. A peony on paper and a black jacket at a meeting do not rule each other out.

Imagine the same black on three women. On a lawyer, a singer and a teenage girl. For the first you might say "professional", for the second "striking", for the third "what's going on with her?". **The colour has not changed. Your expectations have.**

A black wardrobe is not automatically a sign of sadness, reserve or a strong personality. First of all it is the wardrobe of a specific woman.

## When black takes over the space

First, let your hand work. **Black does not have to close anything off.** If you fear it will ruin everything, try it first on a small paper or hold a black cut-out against the picture. You will see the change without having to make it permanent at once.

### Three things worth noticing

- **SHAPE**

*A line, an area, or an overlay?*

A thin black line can join or separate something. A large area can create depth, weight and also a protective space. While working you need not decide what exactly it means. Only later can you ask whether the stroke meant a decisive step, relief or just the pleasure of contrast for you.

- **WEIGHT**

*Firm, or too heavy?*

If black feels pleasantly firm to you, leave it alone for a while and watch its shape. If the area is too heavy, open a smaller light place or try a more translucent layer. If everything blends, add a difference of surface, direction of strokes or lightness.

- **COURAGE**

*You do not have to cut in with the biggest brush at once*

Courage in painting does not have to mean cutting into everything immediately. If you want a striking mark, try a wider tool, charcoal or black on a light ground. If you keep covering earlier layers, notice the feeling of covering itself. The interpretation can wait.



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## What to take from the picture

It does not matter what a black stroke looks like. What matters is what you feel while making it and what is going on in your life at that moment. **Two identical pictures can have a completely different meaning**. One arose in a feeling of strength, the other after a day when you wanted to hide. That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but **questions**.

## A picture can speak even after time

Perhaps later you will link the picture with a period of sadness. Perhaps with a decision that gave you strength. Or you will keep seeing in it mainly a beautiful dark area. In self-reflection inspired by art therapy, what matters is the connection of the picture, your experience and a specific period of life. Black alone does not know your story.

## Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at what you have painted and it tells you nothing. In a week, a month or a year, though, it may suddenly dawn on you. That is fine. **The painting will wait until you are ready to understand it.**

If very strong or painful feelings appear while painting, do not stay alone with them. Talk about them with someone close or with a therapist. This page does not replace professional care.



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# Associations and stories

## Our associations

Associations are the connections that form between us and a colour. We are not born with a ready-made list "black = this", and yet they tend to be surprisingly similar. They are usually made of three layers: **the body**, **culture** and **what we ourselves have lived through**.

### From the body

Black is the colour of **darkness, night and coal**. Darkness limits information. You do not know what is behind the door or at the end of the road, and the imagination starts to work. That helps explain why black can relate to uncertainty as well as mystery.

### From culture

In Europe black is linked with **mourning, celebration and authority**. A judge's gown, a dinner jacket, evening dresses, a funeral. At the same time it is the colour of fashion, photography and cultural projects. We will look at this in more detail in the chapter on cultures.

### From what you have lived

A black dress for a concert, a black coat from your grandmother, the first black T-shirt you bought yourself. These memories decide the most. **Two women can look at the same black** and one feels support, the other weight.

When you know where your associations come from, it is easier to tell what is really "black" and what is your story about it. You can ask yourself now. **What does black connect with first for me, and where do I know it from?**



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# Stories

Black has several stories worth untangling. They show where the colour ends and where what people make of it begins.

## The Black Square

In **1915** Kazimir Malevich painted the picture Black Square, oil on canvas measuring 79.5 by 79.5 centimetres. He showed it at the 0.10 exhibition in Petrograd and, according to descriptions, had it hung in the so-called icon corner, that is, the place where icons used to hang in Orthodox homes.

Malevich said of his pictures that suprematism begins with them, and spoke of 1915 as the "zero point of painting". Four painted versions exist. Black here is neither sadness nor emptiness. It is **a decision to stop depicting and just be**.

## A black car for everyone

The famous sentence "a customer can have a car painted any colour he wants so long as it is black" is attributed to Henry Ford and is said to date from 1909. According to an overview, though, the rule was introduced only in **1914**. From 1908 to 1913 the Model T was not offered in black at all, it came in grey, green, blue or red.

The reasons that repeat are low price, durability and fast drying. According to the same overview, though, there is no evidence that black dried faster than other dark paints. Black pigment was one of the cheapest. Black here did not become a fashion. It became **a practical decision**.

## The blackest black

In July **2014** the company Surrey NanoSystems introduced the Vantablack coating. It consists of vertically growing carbon nanotubes and, according to the manufacturer, absorbs up to 99.965 percent of visible light. The name arose from the abbreviation VANTA (vertically aligned nanotube arrays) and the word black.

When the company granted the artist Anish Kapoor exclusive rights to artistic use, many other artists protested. Black became the subject of a dispute over **who may own a colour**. The later company Nanolab released its own nanotube-based black paint and eased the dispute.



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# Emotions and feelings

The same black can evoke **strength** in one of us and **heaviness** in another, sometimes even both in one day. There is no single fixed effect. It depends on our body, experience, culture and situation.

## Emotions

Quick and strong reactions that can appear even before you realise them.

### Self-assurance

A feeling that you **stand firm** and need not apologise to anyone.

#### And why?

A well-fitting black jacket, a simple dress or striking jewellery can look decisive. Black can let the face, the movement and the detail stand out. Sometimes it is the most striking thing in the room.

Ask yourself

*“When do I feel most like myself?”*

### Protection

A feeling that there is **a firm boundary** around you and nobody sees inside.

#### And why?

In some contemporary spiritual approaches black is used as a symbol of protection. Protection after a hurt is not a failure. At the same time it is good to notice whether the boundary serves you, or separates you from people.

And what if I asked you now?

*“What do I need to protect today, and from what?”*

### Mystery

A wish to **keep something just for yourself** and not explain.

#### And why?

Darkness limits information and the imagination starts to work. Mystery can be pleasant when you choose it yourself. Less pleasant is a mystery that becomes a wall.

And try answering now

*“What am I keeping to myself for now and feel fine with it?”*

### Sadness

A feeling that **everything has gone quiet and dark**.

#### And why?

In European history black had a strong place in mourning dress. It does not show the size of the pain, though. A woman in a coloured jumper can grieve deeply and a woman in a black dress can go to a concert. Grief has no obligatory colour chart.

And now one question for you

*“What am I missing and who could I tell?”*



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## Feelings and experience

Deeper and slower states that settle in us. You often recognise them only after a while.

### Privacy

A feeling that you **need not be available** and can rest for a while.

#### And why?

After a long period when you were constantly available, black may attract you as privacy. Simple clothing, fewer stimuli, less need to explain yourself. The benefit comes from the whole transition into a calmer regime.

Ask yourself

*“When did I last not answer at once and nothing happened?”*

### Boundary

A feeling that **you know where you end** and someone else begins.

#### And why?

A black scarf, a smooth stone or a piece of fabric can be taken as a personal symbol of privacy. Work with boundaries need not end in a firm "nobody in". Perhaps you do not need to share everything. But perhaps you are already hiding even what you would like to say.

And what if I asked you now?

*“Whom do I wish to let closer?”*

### Fear of being seen

A feeling that in another colour **you will be too much in view**.

#### And why?

When you want a pink jumper, but every time you return it because "I will be too visible in it", it is this very worry that deserves attention. But if you love black and a coloured jumper does not tempt you at all, you do not have to re-educate yourself.

And try answering now

*“Do I choose black because I love it, or because I am afraid to be seen in another colour?”*

### Celebration

A feeling that it is **an exceptional evening** and you are part of it.

#### And why?

A black dress, a dinner jacket and evening suits belong to celebrations. The same black dress can mean "I'm saying goodbye", "I'm celebrating" or "this simply suits me". Without the circumstances you don't know.

And now one question for you

*“What am I looking forward to so much that I would wear something exceptional for it?”*



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## My black is not the same as your black

The colour itself **experiences nothing**. We experience it. When we first see a colour together with something strong (a smell, a face, a situation, a word), the **experience** sticks to it. The colour then becomes a **shortcut**. That is why **your own reaction** is the most important.

- **Black dress**
  For one a celebration, for another a funeral.
- **Black coat**
  For one elegance, for another hiding.
- **Black room**
  For one depth and privacy, for another a cave.
- **Black hair**
  For one a frame for the face, for another a change she does not want.
- **Black stone**
  For one protection, for another a piece of earth on the road.

### Why does it attract me right now?

Perhaps you feel well put together in it, it combines easily, you enjoy its strength or you need not deal with every coloured detail in it. And perhaps it really helps you have a sense of privacy. **A black wardrobe is not automatically a sign of sadness, reserve or a strong personality.**

### Does it really slim?

Research on the perception of clothing shows that lower lightness can, under certain conditions, lead to a narrower impression of the figure. It is not a universal trick, though, that overrides every cut, material and light. A black close-fitting glossy garment and a black looser matte dress do not look the same. Try asking yourself two questions. Do I like how I look in it? Or does it mainly calm me that it will perhaps hide something of me?

### When to take black away

When a particular whole weighs on you, you lose your bearings in it or it keeps reminding you of a period you want to step away from. Start with one change. A lighter fabric near the face, an uncovered window or a different cover. Watch the real difference, not the expectation that a colour must fix something at once. **Black can be your choice. It does not have to be your obligation.**

Ask yourself

*"Which sentence about black is loudest in me? Whose is it, actually?"*



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# Black in cultures and traditions

Black is a colour people long thought of as "obvious". Mourning, night, authority. Behind its reputation, though, are **more stories about fashion, commerce and faith than about the colour itself**. Let us visit a few places and read them carefully.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how black is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image, not as instructions. What is verified history and what is later interpretation, I say in each part.

## Black in different cultures

### Egypt

In antiquity Egypt was called Kemet. The name appears from roughly the eleventh to twelfth dynasty and the hieroglyph km means black. Many scholars assume that the name refers to **the fertile black soil around the Nile**.

From a landscape where black is the colour of the earth from which grain grows. According to other interpretations the hieroglyph depicts a piece of smouldering coal.

Black here need not be an end. It can be **soil in which something begins**.

### England

Prince Albert died in **1861** and Queen Victoria mourned so long and so visibly that it influenced the whole society. Victorian etiquette expected widows to mourn for two years and not to appear in society during the first year. Full mourning was followed by half mourning, when muted shades of lilac, grey and lavender could be worn.

From a time when colour became a rule that everyone had to follow, even those who did not feel that way.

Black here is **a social game with exact rules**. Grief, however, has no colour chart.



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### Ghana

The Akan and Asante peoples in Ghana print adinkra cloth. Formerly it was worn by kings and spiritual leaders at funerals and on special occasions. It was printed on white, red, dark brown or black cotton. The patterns are stamped with carved calabash stamps with a dye from boiled bark and roots of the badie tree.

The oldest surviving cloth is from **1817** and since 1818 has been in the British Museum. Traditional production continues in Ntonso near Kumasi.

Black here carries **a word, a sign and a memory**. Not every sign is sad.

### France

In **1926** American Vogue published a picture of Coco Chanel's short, simple black dress. The magazine called it "Chanel's Ford" because it was simple and accessible to women of all classes, and predicted that it would become "a sort of uniform for all women of taste".

Chanel said of black that she had "imposed" it and that it "wipes out everything else around". Black thus moved away from mourning and became a colour of elegance.

A colour can **change its meaning with one good cut**.

## Black in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at black **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and an inspiration, not a healing manual.



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## Traditional Chinese medicine

In the traditional five-element system black is linked with water, winter, the circuit of kidneys and bladder, and with fear. Water here does not mean just a glass on the table. It is also an image of depth, stillness and reserves. In winter not everything is dead just because nothing happens to be blooming.

The traditional kidney circuit is also linked with storing the essence jing. **Black clothing alone does not restore the kidneys or replenish jing.** For our colour story the image may remind you of long-term forces you handle.

**How it relates to black.** After a long period when you were constantly available, black may attract you as privacy. If you find relief in it, it can accompany a moment when you truly rest. Say you put down the phone and change into comfortable clothes. Colour can be part of the experience, **not a substitute for rest**.

And what if I asked you now?

*"What do I no longer want to give out, and what do I need to keep?"*

## Fear, what I can't see I imagine

Darkness limits information. You do not know what is behind the door, and the imagination starts to work. Not every discomfort in a black room is, however, an "imbalance of water". Try to tell whether the colour bothers you, the lack of light, or a memory that the space awakens in you.

## Winter should end with spring too

Stillness can restore strength. If it turns into a long withdrawal in which you are no longer well, there is no need to add more darkness. You can change the lighting, go outdoors in daylight or add to a black base a colour you want to see. **You do not have to choose one position forever.**

Traditional Chinese medicine uses the elements as an image. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace a doctor.



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## Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. It describes a person by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are not assigned to the doshas uniformly in the classical texts, so here you read **modern interpretations**, not an old table.

**How it relates to black.** In Ayurvedically inspired work we can ask about heaviness, lightness, warmth and cold. Black does not give the same experience in every material. A black woollen coat and black silk are quite different worlds.

### Pitta

This describes a woman who is purposeful, quick and thorough, who flares up easily. Matte black and soft materials can feel cooling. Black on glossy metal and sharp contrast may, on the contrary, irritate.

- **Matt and soft**
  *Calming, as a base.*
- **Beware of shine**
  *A sharp contrast can be an extra stimulus.*

### Vata

This describes a woman who is imaginative and quick, but restless and often cold. A warm black in wool and velvet can add warmth and a sense of firm boundaries. **It is best to notice how you really feel in it.**

- **Warm black and wool**
  *Soft and earthy, without chill.*
- **Evening and sleep**
  *Soft textiles and warm light.*

### Kapha

This describes a woman who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily grows heavy. Large dark areas can deepen the heaviness, so give them **a light and lively companion**.

- **A light companion**
  *Cream or wood as a counterweight.*
- **Add movement**
  *Red or yellow as an accent. A scarf, a tablecloth.*

We will therefore not make black a universal ban or a remedy for a particular dosha. More interesting is whether a specific form brings you comfort, or weighs on you.

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.



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## A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

**Jung did not describe black as a colour of its own.** What I write next is my own reflection in the spirit of his thinking, not his statement. In alchemy nigredo, the blackening, means the first phase of transformation. In his works on alchemy Jung interpreted it as a symbolic image of meeting one's own shadow.

**How it relates to black.** In symbolic language you can read black as **the colour of the shadow and of what we do not yet know**. When you think about it, ask what in it is yours and what belongs to the expectations of others.

**What you can take from it.** Jung did not want colours turned into a dictionary. **We always ask what it means for you.** The same black can be a support for one woman and a weight for another. Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic frame, not verified science.



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## Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging space so that it is good to live in. In feng shui interpretations black is commonly linked with water and can accompany the theme of depth, stillness and concentration. Schools differ in the assignments, so take it as one possibility.

## Black is like ink

A little gives a space depth, a whole room turns it into a cave. Privacy is not the amount of black surfaces.

## Simple tips

- **Start small**
  A black frame, shelf or lamp. A black frame does not behave like a black room.
- **Add more lights**
  Switch on several smaller points and add a lighter surface where you look most often.
- **Watch the surface**
  Matte and glossy black feel different. Gloss shows dust and fingerprints.
- **Give it wood**
  Wood, linen and wool add body.
- **Try it in daylight**
  See how it looks both in the morning and in the evening. Do you want to be in it?
- **Try textiles first**
  Before you repaint a wall, try a throw or a larger sample.



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## What people say and what holds true

MYTH Black slims.

TRUTH A uniform dark whole without sharp breaks helps, but more than colour it is the cut and the material that decide. A badly fitting black rescues nothing.

MYTH Black is everywhere the colour of mourning.

TRUTH In many European countries yes, but in parts of Asia white is traditionally worn for mourning. The meaning is carried by custom, not the colour.

MYTH Black in feng shui brings bad luck.

TRUTH Black belongs to the element of water and is linked with depth and calm. A wholly black room without light, however, easily grows heavy. Details and good light are often enough.

## What black goes well with

- **Wood and brown**
  A more bodily, warmer impression. Watch the amount of dark surfaces.
- **Cream**
  A gentler contrast than sharp white.
- **Green**
  Plants stand out strongly against a dark background.
- **Pink**
  Softness or fashionable boldness depending on the shade.
- **Gold**
  A festive detail. Too much shine can look ostentatious.
- **Red and white**
  Red is a very striking pair. White gives clear contrast, but with small patterns it can be distracting.

## Elements

- **Water**
  Black is its natural stand-in. Make sure it does not outweigh.
- **Metal**
  White and light metal lighten it.
- **Wood**
  Green and wood enliven it.
- **Fire**
  Warm light and a red accent warm it up.



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## Feng shui room by room

### Living room

**What works.** A black sofa, shelf or smaller wall can give a space a striking base. Next to **wood**, linen textiles and several smaller lights it feels cosy, not severe. A black picture frame or a thin metal shelf gives the room a line that holds the eye.

**What to watch for.** When all the large surfaces are dark (sofa, carpet, curtains), shapes and light are lost. The room can then feel more like a cinema than a place to sit and talk.

**A simple tip.** Switch on several smaller points instead of one ceiling light and add **a lighter surface** where you look most often. Ask whether you sit better here in the evening than in the morning.

### Kitchen and bathroom

**What works.** Black cupboards, fittings and a thin handle can be beautiful and striking, especially next to a light worktop, wood or white tiles. A black tap is a lovely detail in a bathroom even when everything else is light.

**What to watch for.** On a glossy black surface you will see dust, grease and fingerprints more than you imagined. In hard water pale limescale quickly shows up. If you don't like wiping after every use, choose **a matte surface**.

**A simple tip.** Mind the lighting of the worktop and the material. Add **a difference of lightness** between the floor, wall and fittings so that the space does not merge into one dark surface.

### Bedroom

**What works.** Black bedding, dark curtains or one dark wall behind the bed can create an intimate, enclosed impression. Some enjoy the feeling of a muted refuge, for another a dark bed recalls heaviness.

**What to watch for.** A black wall colour is not the same as blackout for sleep. Street light can penetrate a black room too. Dark bedding also quickly shows hairs and dust.

**A simple tip.** Notice the room in the daytime too. Do you want to be in it? Is it pleasant when you wake up? If not, add **one softer surface** (a beige blanket, linen or light wood) and see whether the impression changes.



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### Children's room

**What works.** If a child or teenager wants black, ask what they like about it. Perhaps music, space, graphics, a poster or striking contrast. A small black element, say a chalkboard on the wall or a shelf, can be the part of the room that belongs only to them.

**What to watch for.** A black wall does not itself say that the child is unhappy. A conversation and overall behaviour will tell you more about their life than a tin of paint. Teenagers often try out with colour who they are.

**A simple tip.** Start with a smaller area, keep good lighting and **the possibility of change**. A black board or wardrobe can be repainted after a year when the child outgrows it.

### Study

**What works.** A dark surrounding can limit some distracting reflections and help focus the gaze on a screen or paper. A black desk or shelf quietens visual noise when there are many small things around.

**What to watch for.** A very bright screen in the middle of a dark room may not be pleasant for the eyes. The contrast between a luminous monitor and a black wall behind it tires.

**A simple tip.** Add ambient lighting, say a lamp behind the monitor or on the desk. Black should not replace **a well-prepared workplace**.

### Hall and entrance

**What works.** A black door, handle, coat rack or bench give the entrance firmness and match the coats and shoes that alternate here. A black mirror frame defines well the place where you check yourself one last time.

**What to watch for.** A narrow dark corridor without a window. There watch orientation and safe stairs so that dark surfaces do not merge with the floor.

**A simple tip.** Add a mirror, a lighter wall and a good lamp. An entrance should be a welcome, not a passage through a tunnel.

And try answering now

*"Why do I want black at home? What should it bring me, privacy, depth, or courage?"*



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# Colour frequency and phototherapy

With black people talk about "absorbing energy" and a "black frequency". It sounds as if it had its own number that could be read off. A black fabric **absorbs** light, a black lamp **does not emit** light. Let us say what of this is **atmosphere** and what is already **treatment**.

And it is just here that it is good to leave aside **miraculous promises**. A black wall or a black filter is not in itself a therapeutic light method.

## Black is not light with a frequency of its own

A black surface usually reflects little visible light. It has no single "black frequency". A room can also look dark because of lack of lighting even though its walls are not black. The colour of an object, the intensity of light and the feel of the surroundings are connected, but not interchangeable.

## Does black absorb energy?

In optics we speak of absorbing radiation. Part of the absorbed energy can show up as heat. It depends on the material, the light and other conditions. It does not follow, though, that a black jumper absorbs the sadness of other people or takes your life force. **Those are spiritual or personal interpretations**, not a continuation of the same physical rule.

## What "black light" means

So-called black light usually means a source of ultraviolet radiation with a small amount of visible light. It is not a black colour shining into the space. And it is not automatically a therapeutic aid. Phototherapy follows the specific kind of radiation, purpose and dose. Health use belongs to **a consultation with the relevant specialist**.

## When it is pleasant to switch off

Dimness can help create privacy and a restful atmosphere. For some more darkness is pleasant, others need a guide light. Notice the difference between "finally I don't have to perceive my surroundings so much" and "I don't feel safe in this space". You don't need to learn to love darkness for your work with colours to be right.



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# Astrotype and colours

Are you Libra, Sagittarius or Pisces? The astrotype is a much broader topic than just the sun sign. If you really want to go into **depth**, knowing only your date of birth is not enough. The exact place and time of birth are also important, because only from them are the ascendant, the position of the Moon, planets and other parts of the horoscope calculated. Here, though, we stay only at the edge of what relates to colours.

**Astrology does not assign black unambiguously.** It is most often linked with Saturn (boundaries, time and structure), sometimes with Pluto (depth and transformation). Sources differ here, so take it as inspiration. Depending on how the planet of your sign relates to black, it may feel close to you, or distant. Find your sign (the dates are approximate and change by year) and read what black may say to you.

The ascendant is the sign that was rising on the eastern horizon at the moment of your birth. According to astrological tradition it shows how you come across outwardly and how you enter the world, while the Sun sign describes more who you are inside. For each sign you will therefore find not only its character but also a short note on how the colour fits when it is your ascendant.

## Aries (21 March – 19 April)

### Your black

black · red · anthracite

A black that **gives you strength without needless noise**.

Aries is linked with Mars, fire and the start of spring. Black is for it like charcoal after a fire, **concentrated strength**. Black with red may suit you more than pastel.

### What Aries is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality cardinal · ruler Mars

Aries opens the zodiac and you can tell that it is first. It is a **pioneer** who gets into things before thinking them through perfectly. It is direct, impatient and likes to compete. It gets angry quickly but forgives quickly too.

Its strength is the **courage** to begin. Weaker is perseverance in long, slow matters. It does best where something is happening and where it can act at once.



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## What it can support in you

Black can support moments when you want to be decisive and do not want to show off. It fits a negotiation, a journey and sport.

With Aries the strength is often in the first step. Black can add **focus** and take away some pointless distraction.

## Shadow hardness instead of strength

In the shadow, Aries wears black as armour. Hardness poses as decisiveness and softness must not show.

Aries fears that if it showed sensitivity, it would lose. So it keeps attacking and never finds out it would have lost less.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **put one soft thing under the black jacket** and show it to no one.

## Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Mars red or white.

red · white · ochre

Red and white give black a clear expression.

## Aries as ascendant

When Aries is your ascendant, you come across as direct, lively and decisive. People may see you as someone who gets straight to the point, and the first impression tends to be brisk.

Black gives you a calm authority. Anthracite and graphite are the closest.

## In everyday life

*Take a smooth black stone in your hand and just hold it for a while.*

*When you feel like attacking, take **a black scarf and five minutes at a window**. You do not have to prove anything.*



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Taurus (20 April – 20 May)

## Your black

charcoal · soot · brown

Black as **velvet and the depth of a material**.

Taurus is an earth sign linked with Venus, the senses and stability. Black suits it naturally, as a **material**, not as an idea. Velvet, leather, silk and wool may feel like luxury without shouting.

## What Taurus is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality fixed · ruler Venus

Taurus is an earthy, **patient** and sensual sign. It likes good food, pleasant materials, nature and security. It gets going slowly, but once it decides on something, it persists.

Its strength is **reliability** and the ability to enjoy the present moment. The weaker side tends to be stubbornness and finding it hard to let go of what is familiar.

## What it can support in you

Black can support the joy of touch and good quality. It fits where you want comfort and elegance at once.

With Taurus it is often not only about colour but about surface. Matte black wool and black velvet feel completely different from a glossy synthetic.

## Shadow a fortress that does not want to listen

In the shadow, Taurus shuts itself behind a rampart and stops listening. Black becomes a wall one cannot get out of.

Taurus likes certainty and black gives it. Only then nothing new comes, because nothing gets through.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **let one thing through**, for example someone else's opinion.



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### Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add green and cream.

green · cream · ochre

Green and cream give black freshness and warmth.

### Taurus as ascendant

When Taurus is your ascendant, you come across as calm, stable and pleasant. You build trust slowly and people often feel firm ground in you.

Black gives you a calm and trustworthy impression. Matte suits more than glossy.

### In everyday life

*Take in your hand something black that you like and notice how it feels under your fingers.*

*Black velvet and a good book.* ***Treat yourself to them without apology.***

## Gemini (21 May – 20 June)

### Your black

blue-black · anthracite · yellow

A black that **calms a head full of ideas**.

Gemini is an air sign linked with Mercury, curiosity and speech. Black suits it as a dark ground on which thoughts stand out. A black notebook, a black pen and **a café at night**.

### What Gemini is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality mutable · ruler Mercury

Gemini is **curious**, talkative and adaptable. It learns quickly, likes to tell stories and enjoys it when a lot is going on around it. It can see several sides of one thing.

Its strength is **lightness** and wit. The weaker side tends to be scatteredness and a tendency to start more things than can be finished.



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## What it can support in you

Black can support moments when you look for room for ideas. It fits a diary, a work desk and a bag.

With Gemini the strength is often in ideas and words. Black can add **focus and depth**.

## Shadow two faces, neither at home

In the shadow, Gemini splits into a public and a hidden face. Black becomes the curtain between them.

Gemini likes to play roles and black helps it change them. Only then nobody knows which is the real one.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **write one sentence that is true for both your faces**.

## Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Mercury yellow or light blue.

yellow · sky blue · white

Yellow and blue add clarity of thought and airiness.

## Gemini as ascendant

When Gemini is your ascendant, you come across as lively, friendly and chatty. People may see you as curious and youthful, even if inside you are perhaps calmer.

Black gives you a more self-assured impression. Blue-black and anthracite are the lightest.

## In everyday life

*Take a black notebook and write down in it three things that interested you today.*

*When it seems you are playing a role, give yourself **a moment of silence with a black thing**. You do not have to joke about everything.*



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## Cancer (21 June – 22 July)

### Your black

charcoal · silver · smoky

Black as **a quiet night room**.

Cancer is a water sign linked with the Moon, home and feeling. Black may seem to it like a soft darkness in which one can rest. Charcoal and smoky may remind you of **a night with a full moon**.

### What Cancer is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality cardinal · ruler Moon

Cancer is **caring**, sensitive and strongly connected to home and family. It has a good memory for feelings and relationships. It enters the world cautiously, much like a crab with its shell.

Its strength is **empathy** and the ability to create safety. The weaker side tends to be changeable moods and a tendency to withdraw when it feels hurt.

### What it can support in you

Black can support moments when you need to hide from the world. It fits a bedroom, a house and clothing.

With Cancer the strength is often in empathy. Black can add **permission for distance**.

### Shadow a refuge into which nobody sees

In the shadow, Cancer closes itself in darkness and nobody finds it. The home turns into a fortress.

Cancers fear being hurt and black offers them hiding. But then nobody knows what they need.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **invite one person for tea** and let them have a look.



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### Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add the Moon's white and silver.

white · silver · cream

White and silver give black light and openness.

### Cancer as ascendant

When Cancer is your ascendant, you come across as gentle and careful. At first you keep your distance, but then warmth unfolds and people see in you someone who will look after them.

Black gives you a sense of calm and protection. Muted and soft shades suit.

### In everyday life

*In the evening take a black mug in your hand and sit for a while without tasks.*

*When you are tired of watching over everything, take **a black scarf and remind yourself** that rest belongs to you too.*

## Leo (23 July – 22 August)

### Your black

black · gold · red

A black that **lets you shine against a dark background**.

Leo is a fire sign ruled by the Sun. Black suits it as a stage on which gold and red stand out. A black jacket, gold jewellery and **a striking lipstick**.

### What Leo is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality fixed · ruler Sun

Leo is **generous**, proud and creative. It likes to give, likes to rejoice and needs others to see and appreciate it. It is loyal and has a big heart.

Its strength is **warmth** and the ability to inspire others. The weaker side tends to be sensitivity to criticism and a tendency to want to be the centre of attention.



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## What it can support in you

Black can support moments when you want to be seen and at the same time keep calm. It fits an evening, a performance and a celebration.

With Leo the strength is often in creativity and generosity. Black can add **calm dignity**.

## Shadow drama as a way to be seen

In the shadow, Leo creates dramatic scenes so that someone notices. Black becomes a curtain that must be raised.

Leo needs recognition and black gives it an impression of depth. When the glances vanish, emptiness arrives.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **choose a black that pleases you**, even if nobody will judge it.

## Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add gold or deep blue.

gold · dark blue · red

Gold and dark blue give black shine and maturity.

## Leo as ascendant

When Leo is your ascendant, you come across as self-assured, warm and striking. You enter a room in a way that people notice you even when you do not want them to.

Black gives you dignity. Anthracite and charcoal suit better than smoky.

## In everyday life

*Put on something black today with one radiant thing.*

*When you feel you must shine, take **a black coat and coloured jewellery**.*



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## Virgo (23 August – 22 September)

### Your black

anthracite · soot · white

Black as **a clean cut and a quiet desk**.

Virgo is an earth sign linked with Mercury, order and care for detail. Black suits it in clean and precise forms. **A black-and-white board, a black pen and clean paper** without needless ornament.

### What Virgo is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality mutable · ruler Mercury

Virgo is **meticulous**, attentive and practical. It notices details that others overlook and likes to be useful. It tends to be modest and judges itself more strictly than others.

Its strength is **reliability** and the ability to improve things. The weaker side tends to be perfectionism, worries and a tendency to criticise itself.

### What it can support in you

Black can support moments when you want to tidy up both space and head. It fits a work desk, a wardrobe and a pantry.

With Virgo the strength is often in attention and order. Anthracite can add **a little forgiveness**.

### Shadow black as the uniform of flawlessness

In the shadow, Virgo wears black so that nobody sees any stain. The colour becomes a shield against judgement.

Virgo is strict with herself and chooses black from a certainty that nothing can be pointed out. Only joy is not there.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **take one thing that nobody will approve**.



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### Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Mercury grey and green.

grey · green · white

Grey and green add order and calm.

### Virgo as ascendant

When Virgo is your ascendant, you come across as neat, restrained and reliable. People see you as observant and sensible, sometimes even overly reserved.

Black gives you a gentle and careful impression. Anthracite suits better than ink.

### In everyday life

*Put a black pen or mug on your desk and do not correct anything about it.*

*When you feel strict, try **leaving one thing imperfect** and looking at it in warm light.*

## Libra (23 September – 22 October)

### Your black

charcoal · silver · powder pink

A black that **suits you in gentleness and style**.

Libra is an air sign ruled by Venus. Black suits it in elegant and balanced forms. Charcoal and silver as **an evening dress with delicate jewellery**.

### What Libra is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality cardinal · ruler Venus

Libra longs for **harmony**, beauty and justice. It is diplomatic, sociable and has a feel for aesthetics. It lives best in relationships in which it does not feel alone.

Its strength is **tact** and the ability to see both sides. The weaker side tends to be hesitation and a tendency to avoid conflict even when it would help.



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## What it can support in you

Black can support moments when you want beauty and balance without shouting. It fits a flat, clothing and work.

With Libra the strength is often in taste and diplomacy. Black can add **permission to stay with your own**.

## Shadow elegance that lets nobody closer

In the shadow, Libra builds elegance as a wall. Black is perfect, and so nobody touches it.

Libra wants everything to match. So she postpones closeness, because it could spoil the appearance.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **let someone see your mess** and let them stay.

## Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Venus green and white.

green · white · powder pink

Green and white add calm and reality.

## Libra as ascendant

When Libra is your ascendant, you come across as elegant, pleasant and balanced. People like you for your tact, even if inside you take a long time to decide.

Black gives you a pleasant and balanced impression. Charcoal suits your manner best.

## In everyday life

*Try a black scarf or a stone bowl on the table and notice what you like and what merely does not bother you.*

*When everything feels too perfect to you, give yourself **one thing in a softer shade** that has a voice of its own.*



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## Scorpio (23 October – 21 November)

### Your black

ink · wine · black

A black that **allows depth without drama**.

Scorpio is a water sign linked with Mars and Pluto, depth and transformation. Black is for it the night, **in which something can be left to ripen**. Ink and wine may be closer to you than smoky.

### What Scorpio is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality fixed · ruler Mars, in the newer view also Pluto

Scorpio is **intense**, deep and loyal. It feels strongly, but does not always show it. It dislikes superficiality and likes to get to what is hidden.

Its strength is **determination** and the ability to transform. The weaker side tends to be distrust, jealousy and a need to keep things under control.

### What it can support in you

Black can support moments when you want to be close, but in your own way. It suits a private detail.

With Scorpio the strength is often in depth and loyalty. Ink can add **calm after the storm**.

### Shadow a darkness you choose so you need not look

In the shadow, Scorpio switches off the light so as not to see what hurts. Black serves as a lock.

After being hurt, Scorpios open up with difficulty. Black means for them that nobody sees anything, and at the same time nobody knows anything.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you **take one thing out and put it in the light**.

### Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add black with dark wine.

wine · red · black

Wine and red give black warmth and depth.



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### Scorpio as ascendant

When Scorpio is your ascendant, you come across as focused, mysterious and strong. People sense the intensity of your gaze and often feel that you know more than you say.

Black gives you a calm depth behind a mysterious impression. Ink is the closest.

### In everyday life

*Try having black just for yourself in something nobody sees.*

*When you want to withdraw, put on **black jewellery under your clothes** and let it be your secret.*

## Sagittarius (22 November – 21 December)

### Your black

soot · brown · gold

Black as **a night by the campfire**.

Sagittarius is a fire sign linked with Jupiter, freedom and distances. Black suits it as the colour of the night sky above the road. Soot and brown as **embers after a fire**.

### What Sagittarius is like according to astrological tradition

Element fire · quality mutable · ruler Jupiter

Sagittarius is **optimistic**, open and free-spirited. It loves travel, new experiences and the search for meaning. It speaks honestly, sometimes a little too directly.

Its strength is **enthusiasm** and faith in a good outcome. The weaker side tends to be impatience with detail and a tendency to promise more than can be managed.

### What it can support in you

Black can support moments when you want to set out but have somewhere to return to. It fits a journey, nature and a café.

With Sagittarius the strength is often in optimism and momentum. Black can add **the awareness of where you set out from**.



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### Shadow black humour instead of an answer

In the shadow, Sagittarius jokes about what troubles it. Black becomes a mask for a joke.

Sagittarians love lightness and black humour gives them an impression of perspective. Only then nobody knows what they truly feel.

The colour can help you here too. It helps to **say one sentence seriously** and endure the silence after it.

### Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Jupiter blue or gold.

blue · gold · green

Blue and gold give black reach and momentum.

### Sagittarius as ascendant

When Sagittarius is your ascendant, you come across as open, jovial and adventurous. People see you as someone with a wide outlook and an appetite for discovery.

Black gives you a friendly and open impression. Soot and brown suit more than ink.

### In everyday life

*Take a black scarf or mug on the road and put it in the same place after you return.*

*When something feels tight, try **looking to see whether it is only closeness**.*

## Capricorn (22 December – 19 January)

### Your black

anthracite · black · slate

A black that **lets you be firm and calm**.

Capricorn is an earth sign linked with Saturn, responsibility and perseverance. Black suits it naturally, as the colour of order and authority, **proven by long years**. Anthracite and slate add a maturity that can warm.



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## What Capricorn is like according to astrological tradition

Element earth · quality cardinal · ruler Saturn

Capricorn is **responsible**, goal-oriented and disciplined. It likes to build and is not afraid of a long road. It has a dry sense of humour and shows it only to those it trusts.

Its strength is **perseverance** and the ability to see things through. The weaker side tends to be strictness with itself, reserve and a tendency to put joy off until later.

## What it can support in you

Black can support moments when you want to lay a firm foundation. It fits an office, a negotiation and long-term plans.

With Capricorn the strength is often in order and perseverance. Anthracite can add **a willingness to rest**.

## Shadow seriousness that hides tiredness

In the shadow, Capricorn wears black so that nobody sees it can no longer go on. Black becomes the uniform of duty.

Capricorn fears that if it rested, it would achieve nothing. Then even pleasures are just another task.

The colour can help you here too. It can help you **find one place where nothing gets improved**.

## Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add Saturn grey and cream.

slate · cream · brown

Grey and cream give black weight and warmth.

## Capricorn as ascendant

When Capricorn is your ascendant, you come across as serious, mature and reserved. People may see you as older than you are, and only later discover how funny you are.

Black gives you a trustworthy and calm impression. Anthracite works best.



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### In everyday life

*Put a black lining or button on serious clothing.*

*When you are too strict, try to **look at a black thing and not improve anything**.*

## Aquarius (20 January – 18 February)

### Your black

ink · sky blue · silver

Black as **an unexpected idea** among colours.

Aquarius is an air sign linked with Saturn and Uranus, independence and ideas. Black belongs to it as an inconspicuous choice that surprises. Ink next to silver looks like **the colour of a calm future**.

### What Aquarius is like according to astrological tradition

Element air · quality fixed · ruler Saturn, in the newer view also Uranus

Aquarius is **independent**, original and idealistic. It is interested in ideas, humanity and the future. It wants to go its own way and does not like adapting to expectations.

Its strength is **perspective** and the ability to come up with new things. The weaker side tends to be distance from feelings and a tendency to withdraw when there is too much closeness.

### What it can support in you

Black can support moments when you want something unusual, but with calm. It fits a poster, a logo and clothing.

With Aquarius the strength is often in originality and perspective. Black can add **firm ground under ideas**.



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### Shadow black as a stance, not a feeling

In the shadow, Aquarius wears black as a stance against everything. Distance poses as independence and the feeling stays unspoken.

Aquarians like to keep a detached view and black makes that easy for them. Only then the body waits for a touch that does not come.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you **take something rough and natural in your hand** and just notice it for a while.

### Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add a cool blue or silver.

sky blue · silver · white

Blue and silver give black clarity and distance.

### Aquarius as ascendant

When Aquarius is your ascendant, you come across as independent, a little unusual and friendly. People see you as an original personality who keeps their own space.

Black gives you an unexpected and friendly impression. Ink and silver are the closest.

### In everyday life

*Try putting one black thing in your bag for a week and not explaining it.*

*When everything seems too neutral to you, try **telling yourself what you like about it**.*

## Pisces (19 February – 20 March)

### Your black

ink · blue-black · violet-grey

Black as **deep water**.

Pisces is a water sign linked with Jupiter and Neptune, feeling and imagination. Black can give it depth and silence. Ink and blue-black may remind you of **the sea at night**.



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## What Pisces is like according to astrological tradition

Element water · quality mutable · ruler Jupiter, in the newer view also Neptune

Pisces is **empathic**, intuitive and dreamy. It picks up the moods around it and often has a rich imagination. It frequently has a bond with art, music and spirituality.

Its strength is **compassion** and creative fantasy. The weaker side tends to be merging with other people's feelings, escaping into dreams and difficulty setting boundaries.

## What it can support in you

Black can support moments when you need to anchor yourself. It fits a bedroom, a picture and a scent.

With Pisces the strength is often in empathy and imagination. Black can add **a willingness to stand firm even in a current**.

## Shadow losing outlines in the dark

In the shadow, Pisces gets lost in black and cannot tell what is its own and what is someone else's. The dark becomes a home.

Pisces are sensitive and easily take on someone else's atmosphere. Black gives them comfort, but not direction.

The colour can also help you here. It helps you **have one thing at home that you chose yourself**.

## Counterbalance what to balance it with

Add black with blue or green.

blue · green · cream

Blue and green give black water and soil.

## Pisces as ascendant

When Pisces is your ascendant, you come across as gentle, dreamy and adaptable. People like to project their wishes onto you and tend to be kind to you.

Black gives you a soft and calm impression. Blue-black and ink are the closest.



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### In everyday life

*In the evening light a candle, take a black stone and write three sentences about your day.*

*When you feel like running away, take* ***a black thing firmly in your hand*** *and return to the room.*

FOR A DEEPER LOOK

**Seasons**

Black is the colour of winter and long evenings. Darkness comes early and black clothes suit the dimness. Summer leaves it rather for the evening. Ask yourself when you reach for it.

**Time of day**

Night and deep evening belong to black most. Morning is mostly too sharp for it and the light shows an undertone that gets lost in the evening.

**Years of life**

Saturn orbits the Sun in roughly 29 years. Astrology speaks of its returns at about 29 and 58 and reads them as times when a person asks what is truly their own. Black may feel close to you in those years as a reminder of boundaries, or on the contrary foreign, like a farewell to a role that only protected itself. Both are natural. Research by Palmer and Schloss (2010) also reports that we like colours according to the things and experiences we link with them. Astrology does not rule that out, it merely offers another view.



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## Colour for your website and business

Yes, mainly where you sell depth, elegance and focus. Black promises seriousness, but can easily feel unapproachable.

In business, black is a colour that **invites trust**, but at the same time carries a label of austerity. It can look luxurious, serious, modern and also mysterious. That is why it is good to know what you are promising before you let it into your logo, website or advert.

By itself, though, it **does not attract customers** like a magnet. It can help create **a striking impression**, but what still decides is mainly **what you sell**, **to whom** and **how well** it all works together.

### What we are telling the customer

Black can say, for example

*"It's premium." "It's serious." "It's modern." "It's private."*

- **Luxury and elegance.** Black is often used in fashion, photography, jewellery and premium services.
- **Authority.** Law, finance and professional services. Too many dark surfaces and austere wording, though, can feel unapproachable.
- **Privacy.** A dark surrounding feels intimate. One must be able to read the menu in it and move about safely.
- **Contrast.** A dark background highlights the shine of metal, light ceramics or a striking photograph.
- **Coldness.** Without a warm companion it can seem aloof.

Depending on the shade it also feels different. Anthracite and charcoal are **modern and restrained**, warm soot **softer and tangible**, pure black **striking and graphic**.



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## Simple tips

- **Add light**
  A light background or a white area adds distance. Keep large areas calm.
- **Show the product**
  A black handbag on a black background can be elegant, if a person actually finds it.
- **Shade by role**
  Pure black for graphics, anthracite for professionalism, warm for friendliness.
- **Legibility**
  Light lettering on a dark background is not automatically comfortable for everyone. Watch size, contrast and the length of text.
- **A human face**
  Authority does not have to stand in the doorway with folded arms. Add clear language and a photograph.
- **Colour blindness**
  About 1 in 12 men has difficulty telling red from green. Black text on a light background is the safest choice for most people.

## Professions where it is a Yes

The rule is simple. When you sell exceptionality, depth or privacy, black can help you.

### Fashion, jewellery and original work

A dark background can highlight the shine of metal, light ceramics or a striking photograph. With dark products, though, make sure they do not disappear.

### Photography, film and culture

Black lets the image, the light and the detail stand out. It suits a gallery, a cinema and a poster.

### Law, finance and professional services

Black can support a serious and restrained impression. If you want people not to be afraid to get in touch, add clear language and a human face.

### Restaurants, bars and social spaces

A dark surrounding can feel intimate and festive. One must be able to read the menu in it and move about safely, though. Mystery is pleasant in the story of a wine. Less so with the question of where the step ends.



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## Professions where it is a No

This is not a ban for whole fields. What decides is the interplay of colour, text, photographs and setting.

- **Caring for people.** Without warmer elements black can feel aloof.
- **Playful and light services.** For services promising lightness and playfulness it may create different expectations.
- **Poorly lit waiting rooms and corridors.** More dark surfaces can strengthen the heaviness.
- **Long texts on a website.** Light lettering on a dark background is not automatically the most comfortable for everyone.
- **Presenting skin, food or coloured products.** A black filter can distort real colours.

Most important is not whether a design looks expensive. It is whether a person understands where they have come and what they can expect.

## Before you send it out into the world

Show the design to a woman who does not know your offer and ask "What would you expect from such a place or service?" **Is the offer visible, or mainly the black?** Her answer may tell you more than the general rule that black means elegance.

A question for you

*"What should your customer feel first when she looks at your website?"*



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## Examples from the market

You know black from notebooks, pens and shoes. Here are **a few examples** that show what it can do.

- **Moleskine (stationery)**
  The brand was founded in Milan in 1997 by Maria Sebregondi. The notebooks have black hard covers, an elastic band and ivory paper. They follow on from the French carnets moleskines that Bruce Chatwin wrote about in his 1987 book The Songlines.

- **Montblanc (writing instruments)**
  The company arose in Berlin in 1906 and was later based in Hamburg. The white star appeared in 1913 and the name Meisterstück was first used in 1924. Black here stands next to a white emblem.

- **Air Jordan 1 (footwear)**
  The basketball shoe was on sale from 1 April 1985. According to available data it had only 23 percent white, while the NBA required 51, and Nike paid a $5,000 fine per game. The "Banned" advert turned it into a story. Black became a protest and an advert.

- **Ray-Ban Wayfarer (glasses)**
  The model was designed in 1952 by Raymond Stegeman for Bausch & Lomb with a new plastic-moulding technology. The dark frame became its hallmark.

What they have in common is that black carries a simple message. **Seriously, strikingly, without apology.** And it mostly does not outweigh what is around it.

Colours in business are not law. Studies are mixed and a lot depends on context, on customers and on how consistent the brand is. Take it as an idea to test, not as a rule. The brand examples are publicly known and the facts about them come from public sources.



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# Different colour combinations

## Black + red

### How it feels

**Strength and fire.** Red gives black life and black gives red depth. Together they look like glowing coals.

### When it suits

When you want **expression and courage**.

### Specific shades



black + red
*strikingly*



charcoal + burgundy
*deeply*



anthracite + coral
*dramatically*



ink black + scarlet
*provocatively*



soot + brick
*subduedly*

### In practice

A black jacket and red lipstick. A black wall and a red picture.

### Watch out

Two strong colours tend to be loud. Add **white or cream**.

## Black + orange

### How it feels

**Night and fire.** Orange warms black up and black calms orange. Together they look modern and playful.

### When it suits

When you want **warmth with distance**.

### Specific shades



black + orange
*radiantly*



charcoal + terracotta
*richly*



anthracite + apricot
*playfully*



ink black + pumpkin
*daringly*



soot + rust
*earthily*

### In practice

A black sofa with an orange cushion. A black bag and an orange scarf.

### Watch out

Too much orange next to black shouts. Try to **mute it with something earthier**.



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## Black + yellow

### How it feels

**Night and light.** Yellow lights black up and black gives yellow expression. Together they look like a warning sign and like a lamp behind a window.

### When it suits

When you want **a clear signal**.

### Specific shades


black + yellow
*cheerfully*


charcoal + ochre
*golden*


anthracite + butter
*strikingly*


ink black + lemon
*radiantly*


soot + mustard
*subduedly*

### In practice

A black coat and a yellow scarf. A black wall and a yellow vase.

### Watch out

At equal intensity the colours pull against each other. Leave yellow **as an accent**.

## Black + green

### How it feels

**Leaves out of shadow.** Green stands out against a black background. Together they look like plants at night.

### When it suits

When you want **a natural and deep impression**.

### Specific shades


black + green
*naturally*


charcoal + bottle green
*woodland*


anthracite + mint
*freshly*


ink black + emerald
*strikingly*


soot + sage
*quietly*

### In practice

A green plant in front of a black wall. Bottle green and black in a kitchen.

### Watch out

A sharp green next to black sounds loud. **Mute** the green.



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## Black + blue

### How it feels

**Night sky.** Blue cools black and black deepens blue. Together they feel calm and serious.

### When it suits

When you want **calm and depth**.

### Specific shades



black + blue
*calmly*



charcoal + dark blue
*deeply*



anthracite + sky
*airily*



ink black + cobalt
*freshly*



soot + denim
*soberly*

### In practice

A blue jumper and black trousers. A light blue wall and black furniture.

### Watch out

Both tend to be cool. Without warmth the whole can seem **cold**.

## Black + indigo

### How it feels

**Ink.** Indigo gives black depth and black gives indigo firmness. Together they look like night with a hint of blue.

### When it suits

When you want **depth without heaviness**.

### Specific shades



black + indigo
*at dusk*



charcoal + ink
*deeply*



anthracite + twilight blue
*firmly*



ink black + ultramarine
*dramatically*



soot + grey-indigo
*soberly*

### In practice

An indigo coat and black shoes. Navy and black in an office.

### Watch out

Dark and dark blend. Add **a light colour**.



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## Black + violet

### How it feels

**Night and mystery.** Purple gives black dreaminess and black gives purple firmness. Together they feel sensual and mysterious.

### When it suits

When you want **sensuality and depth**.

### Specific shades


black + purple
*dreamily*


charcoal + plum
*mysteriously*


anthracite + lavender
*deeply*


ink black + orchid
*richly*


soot + grey-violet
*dustily*

### In practice

Plum and black in a dress. Purple jewellery on a black jumper.

### Watch out

Too much darkness and purple can feel heavy. Add **a light colour**.

## Black + pink

### How it feels

**Hardness and softness.** Pink softens black and black sets off pink. Together they look modern and a little rebellious.

### When it suits

When you want **expression and softness**.

### Specific shades


black + pink
*modernly*


charcoal + raspberry
*dramatically*


anthracite + powder
*gently*


ink black + fuchsia
*provocatively*


soot + old rose
*discreetly*

### In practice

A black jacket and a pink shirt. A blackboard and pink chalk.

### Watch out

Two strong colours tend to be loud. Add **white**.



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## Black + grey

### How it feels

**Elegance.** Grey softens black and black deepens grey. Together they look tasteful and sober.

### When it suits

When you want **elegance without shouting**.

### Specific shades



black + grey
*soberly*



charcoal + graphite
*elegantly*



anthracite + silver
*lightly*



ink black + slate
*modernly*



soot + dove
*quietly*

### In practice

A black jacket and a grey jumper. A blackboard and grey chalk.

### Watch out

Two dark colours tend to be heavy. Add **a light element**.

## Black + brown

### How it feels

**Earth and night.** Brown warms black and black deepens brown. Together they look serious, but with warmth.

### When it suits

When you want **depth and nature**.

### Specific shades



black + brown
*dramatically*



charcoal + chocolate
*deeply*



anthracite + beige
*soberly*



ink black + caramel
*elegantly*



soot + linen
*discreetly*

### In practice

A black jacket and brown boots. A black kitchen unit and a wooden worktop.

### Watch out

Two dark colours tend to be heavy. Add **white or cream**.



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## Black + white

### How it feels

**Chessboard.** White brightens black and black sets off white. Together they look clear and graphic.

### When it suits

When you want **clear contrast**.

### Specific shades



black + white
*cleanly*



charcoal + ivory
*elegantly*



anthracite + snow
*graphically*



ink black + milk
*strikingly*



soot + bone
*soberly*

### In practice

A black-and-white photograph. A white shirt and a black jacket.

### Watch out

With small patterns the contrast can be distracting. Add **one calm area**.

## Black + gold

### How it feels

**Celebration.** Gold highlights black and gives it shine. Together they look festive and luxurious.

### When it suits

When you want **celebration with depth**.

### Specific shades



black + gold
*festively*



charcoal + antique gold
*richly*



anthracite + champagne
*gently*



ink black + rich gold
*radiantly*



soot + matte gold
*subduedly*

### In practice

Gold jewellery on a black dress. Black packaging with gold lettering.

### Watch out

In excess gold drowns out calm and the space recalls **a shop window**.



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A SIMPLE RULE

- When you want to **soften** black, add **cream**, **grey**, **wood** or **linen**.
- When you want to **bring it to life**, add **green**, **yellow** or **pink**.
- When you want to **deepen** it, **indigo**, **dark blue** or **purple** will help.
- When you want to **emphasise** it, add **white**, **gold** or **red**.



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